hunt for ratings will do to such a critical industry!

I'm not going to pin all the blame about the Indo–Pak mess on just the media, though. Context is required. 2016 was a loaded trip. Things were bad politically and bilaterally between Nawaz Sharif's Pakistan and Narendra Modi's India, and there was doubt about our tour from the get-go because of the security situation on the ground. For days, we were stuck at the National Cricket Academy in Lahore, awaiting the green light from Indian security to travel across the border. There was no contact permitted with the outside world. When our tour finally began, we were already pretty roughed up with cabin fever. In fact, there were sections in Pakistan which said that we shouldn't have been going on tour in the first place.

And then came the tour, followed by my statement, which caused more fireworks. The only Indian politician who came to my rescue was Mamata Banerjee, the honourable chief minister of West Bengal, who pulled me aside after a match and thanked me for my comments. She was someone who actually got what I had implied in my statement. Otherwise, nobody made the letter-versus-spirit distinction, and it was a real mess: a friendly comment intended to create warm ties backfired and got me into trouble both in India and back home. Eventually, after my qualifying statements – and I had to make a few – everybody, the fans, the teams, came on the same page, except for the Indian media which kept on harping about my lack of patriotism and how I was a self-hating Pakistani.

Back to my foreign-minister-for-a-day fantasy. Here's my advice: fix sporting ties with India. Now. If peace is the objective, then sports is the way to get there. Cricket. Hockey. Football. Kabaddi. Chess. Men. Women. U-19. More tours. More spectators. More cross-border traffic. Start small. Build big. Everything will improve if sports ties do. The money will follow. I dare anyone to prove me wrong. But that is *only if* peace is the objective.

Pakistan is game for such a relationship. I'm saying this because I've discussed the matter with several top officials, in and out of uniform. But if the intentions of the Indian leadership are not right for Pakistan, and if permanent hostility is on the cards, then what can one do? Nothing.

Thus, it boils down to the quality of leadership. Vajpayee sahib was a different kind of leader. A polite, thoughtful and gracious man. He loved chatting with our team, asking us questions, being genuinely inquisitive and curious about Pakistan and Pakistanis, beyond making polite small talk about things not necessarily related to officialdom. Things were different then. India too was different, I guess. Manmohan Singh sahib was a quieter man but also as nice a guy as Vajpayee sahib. Modi sahib, even though I don't recall meeting him, is cut from a different cloth. The less said, the better.

I repeat: most of the people out there in India are great. Bollywood, for example, has some of the kindest and humblest people. Shah Rukh Khan. Aamir Khan. Others. They're all so down to earth, so humble, the high achievers that they are. Then there are the thinkers, leaders, journalists, artists and, of course, the sportspersons I've bumped into. Most of them always stress on the importance of improving cross-border ties. They're so curious about understanding Pakistan. They're so worried about the lack of Indo–Pak cricket. They're actually concerned about our region, our people and our future.

But if I were to connect the dots and separate the snakes from the ladders, the current state of Indian vitriol and the absence of Indo–Pak cricket can be traced to a few political leaders and, of course, the Indian media. Yes, politicians will be politicians. They will play to the gallery. So I will